1. Iron objects such as hoes, sickles, knives, hooks, nails, arrowheads, vessels and mirrors confirm the widespread use of iron technology.
2. Textiles, beads, pottery, ivory objects, ceramics and glassware and artefacts of other metals are found.
3. A large number of terracotta artefacts have also been found.

Some of the urban features revealed by excavation of the various cities are as follows:

1. Northern Black Polished Ware (NBPW), considered luxury-ware and "urban hallmark" have been excavated.
2. The towns were Rajagriha, Kaushambi enclosed by a moat and sometimes they were fortified.
3. Houses were built with mud bricks and in some cases with burnt bricks.
4. Facilities such as drains, ring wells and soak-pits are found, confirming the second urbanisation in the Gangetic plains.

3.1 Developments in the Gangetic Plain

Agriculture improved during this phase of development in the middle Gangetic plains. Wet rice cultivation began to yield more produce of rice than other crops, thus creating the necessary agrarian surplus. Protected irrigation alone was not responsible for the surplus production of rice. Iron technology also played a crucial role. While it is debated whether iron axe aided clearing of the forests or whether iron ploughshare increased agricultural yield, there can be no two opinions that it played a critical role in improving the production of artefacts. The impact of iron technology is better understood if one considers "the technical changes which the introduction of iron implements would have brought about in various craft activities". Leisure time provided by agricultural surplus and technology led to growth of crafts, which in turn aided vibrant trade.

Second Urbanisation

Agricultural surplus, the growth of crafts and trade, and the growing population led to the emergence of towns in the Gangetic plains. This is called the second urbanisation in Indian history after the first urbanisation evident in the Harappan Civilization. Different types of towns came into being:

1. Political and administrative centres such as Rajagriha, Shravasti, Kaushambi and Champa
2. Centres of trade and commerce such as Ujjain and Taxila
3. Holy centres such as Vaishali.



Vaishali

3.2 Janapadas to Mahajanapadas

The Later Vedic period (1000–600 BCE) witnessed the transition from a tribal polity based on lineage to a territorial state. The *janas* who migrated eastwards began to settle down in various regions. The loyalty of the people shifted from *jana* (tribe or clan) to *janapada* (territory). *Janapada* literally meant 'the place where the tribe sets its foot upon.' The *janapadas* fought with one another for resources and political dominance. Some *janapadas* extended their territories and brought various *janas* within their jurisdiction. Such *janapadas* grew into *mahajanapadas.*

Territory, people, government and sovereignty are important elements of a state. All these elements were found in some of the *mahajanapadas.* The *mahajanapadas*

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